thought the involvement of an intermediary like India would only let China and the US off the hook in terms of talking to each other directly.[195]

When Nehru traveled to the US that December, Dulles expected him to try to mediate between China and the US in order to help Sino-Indian relations.[196] China did come up in conversations with both Eisenhower and Dulles, but Nehru was not as much of an activist on the subject as he had been in the past. Publicly, too, he brushed aside the idea of India being "a bridge" between China and the US, stating that it was unnecessary and caused India too much embarrassment.[197]

Nehru's winter 1956–1957 meetings with Eisenhower and Dulles, and then Zhou, appeared to change the prime minister's attitude in a crucial way that would benefit US-India relations: he came to see the Chinese as more intransigent. Before traveling to the US, Nehru had written to the Chinese premier. He had noted that it would be in Chinese interest to release the American prisoners; their continued captivity suggested China was holding hostages.[198] But Zhou had dismissed his advice.[199]

In the US, Nehru noticed that China—and especially its imprisonment of Americans—was the only issue that really riled up Eisenhower.[200] The president highlighted American efforts to resolve the issue with China, a country he called "a number one priority." He told Nehru that the existing state of Sino-US relations, marred by the legacy of Korea, was neither normal nor sustainable. Both he and Dulles pointed out, however, that the prisoner question was a major stumbling block, not least with the American public.[201]

In subsequent conversations with Zhou in Delhi in January 1957, the prime minister explained that Eisenhower did not subscribe to the views of the China lobby. But the latter and Chinese actions like the continued imprisonment of Americans created an atmosphere that constrained the president's policymaking space.[202] A fed-up Nehru told foreign ministry officials that, despite his pleading, Zhou did not "budge an inch."[203] His frustration was evident in his subsequent conversations with the Chinese premier. After listening to Zhou list American faults and insist that China desired peace, Nehru asserted that merely criticizing the other side would only exacerbate tensions.[204]

Earlier Nehru had seen the US as the intransigent country, but by spring 1957 he had come to question the Chinese leadership's desire for a peaceful